Media

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How to be successful on Odin

In this three minute video, you will learn what you need to be successful on Project Odin.

Welcome to Odin

Please watch this video carefully.

Written overview

Below, you will find a written overview of Project Odin.

About Project Odin

Project Odin trains AI to do various tasks on macOS.

We do this by recording your screen while you work through a realistic task from your own profession or area of expertise. You record work you actually do, working in the apps you actually use, while narrating what you're doing and why you do it that way. Your recordings teach AI how skilled professionals really get work done.

The work flow

You come up with ideas for realistic tasks, then you actually do them while recording yourself. We'll walk you through it at each step:

1. **Create your idea:** propose a realistic task from your profession and submit it for approval.
2. **How to make a high quality submission:** learn the criteria your recording is graded on before you record.
3. **Set up your tech:** get your Mac and TaskRecorder ready.
4. **Submitting your task:** record your task, upload your files and submit.

To start, let's make sure you have the right tech. This step is absolutely critical for success on this project.

Check your Mac

Confirm you have the right Mac and software for this project:

- **Chip:** Apple silicon (**M1 or newer**) or **Intel**. Check under Apple menu → About This Mac. On Intel Macs, use **TaskRecorder2.4.4-Intel.dmg** from the **Download TaskRecorder** card in **Set up your tech**.
- **Software: macOS 15** or newer.
- **Storage:** at least **35 GB** free (System Settings → General → Storage).

Mandatory: answer two questions in the checklist below.

Last step: Start Insightful

Insightful records eligible hourly work on Odin. First-task milestones and qualifying older per-task work follow the separate pay rules below. To download and install it, visit the help guide and follow the steps until you have signed in with your **@mercor.expert** account. Start its **Odin** timer for eligible hourly work, subject to the exceptions below.

Run Insightful for eligible active hourly work within your applicable allowance or firm weekly cap; pause for breaks. Keep it off for qualifying older tasks retaining prior per-task terms. Tracking first-task milestone work does not make it hourly. See the Payments guidelines for the exact eligibility and October 23 submission deadline.

📘 **In the Writer Guidelines:** [MacOS Requirement] To access the writer guidelines, sign in via Okta at https://c-mercor.okta.com/ and select Google Drive. For more information about Okta, see our Okta help guide.task

Watch: Setting up Insightful

Your Pay

Watch: Your Pay

Your Pay Explained

Your pay on Odin

Effective October 21, 2026 at 12:00 a.m. Pacific. All writers move to this model. Your base hourly rate is the rate in your contract. Previously hourly writers must receive and accept the amendment to reactivate before resuming hourly work. Task-paid writers may continue under their existing terms while the amendment is pending. Accept within 48 hours of receipt; the separate old-task cutoff and submission protections still apply. **Questions about your pay?** Get your answers here

1. Onboarding

- Up to **3 actual setup hours** are paid at your base rate. The 3 hours are a one-time total.

- If you reach that cap, keep going: **The first task itself is not paid hourly.** You receive **$150 on its first submission** and **$250 when it first reaches Ready for Delivery (RFD)**. Each milestone is paid once; resubmitting does not earn another submission bonus.
- Hitting the 3-hour cap **doesn't stop you from earning either one**. Finish your task, submit it, and you're on track for both.
- The first RFD unlocks Trial. If your base is $40/hour, setup pays up to $120 and the complete initial package is up to $520.

If you have not received any onboarding or first-task bonuses, the $150 submission payment and $250 RFD payment apply to your first new task under the updated terms, even if you have earlier Review Approved tasks. Both payments refer to that same new task, once each. Eligible older tasks retain their separate prior terms. This does not create duplicate bonuses or additional setup hours.

2. Trial

- Eligible work hours within your approved limit are paid at your base rate. You start with **12 hours on Insightful**; each task that reaches RFD adds **3 hours**.
- After **3 Trial tasks reach RFD**, you enter Production as a **Writer**. Review Approved alone doesn't count, and rejected tasks don't count toward the 3.
- Keep no more than **3 open tasks**. If your Trial allowance genuinely reaches zero, finish the current task without further hourly pay until RFD unlocks 3 more paid hours. Discretionary top-ups are unavailable. For an incorrect balance, missing earned hours or tracking failure, pause hourly-paid work and ask **Maven** in #odin--helpdesk to check it. In Production, stop at your firm weekly cap.

3. Production

Tier	Hourly pay	Weekly hour limit	Open task limit
Throttled	Your base rate	40	3
Writer	1.375 times your base rate	60	5
Super Writer	1.875 times your base rate	80	10

If your base is **$40/hour**, these rates are **$40 / $55 / $75**. Tiers are reviewed regularly. Efficiency uses several metrics, primarily the hours needed to deliver usable tasks at RFD. A warning keeps your current pay while you have time to recover; your tier can change if performance does not recover. Persistently very low efficiency may lead to removal. Open tasks include tasks awaiting approval; rejected tasks are closed.

Track your work and get paid

Keep **Insightful running for actual work**, including preparation, retakes and rejected work; pause for breaks and stay within your hour allowance. Hours above the applicable Trial allowance or firm Production cap are not paid; discretionary top-ups are unavailable. Idle or off-project time is not paid. Tracking your first task does not turn its fixed milestones into hourly pay. Keep Insightful off for qualifying older tasks retaining prior per-task terms.

Hourly pay is sent on **Wednesday** for the prior Saturday–Friday week (IST). Tier bonuses nomrally follow the next Wednesday but may arrive earlier.

Read the Payments guidelines and pay walkthrough for the full guidance. Contact **Maven** with questions about your placement or allowance

Before you start: checklist

Mandatory: complete this checklist before you move forward.

Does your Mac meet all three requirements?

Apple silicon (M1 or newer) or Intel processor (Apple menu → About This Mac). macOS 15 or newer. At least 35 GB of free storage (System Settings → General → Storage).

Yes, my Apple silicon or Intel Mac runs macOS 15 or newer and has at least 35 GB free

Is Insightful installed, signed in, and running on Odin?

Keep it running in the background whenever you work on Odin. Insightful help guide

Yes, Insightful is running on Odin

How to make a high quality task

In this section we walk you through how to ensure you are aubmitting a high quality task.

Watch: How to create a high quality task

1. Create your idea

In this section, you will outline your proposed idea for the recording you will submit.

Watch: A sample idea

Watch this for a sense of how to go through the idea flow. Come up with a real task idea for yours!

What your idea must include

In this section we give you instructions for what your idea submission must include to be accepted.

Your idea should be something you know well, that requires apps on your device, and is something that can teach the model something it doesn't already know.

Need help with a task idea? Ask Loki in #odin--ideation in Slack. Remember to tag Loki to start, then keep replying in your thread.

Rules: no banned apps (do not select any apps with 🚫 RESTRICTED). Any other app is fine. No AI during the recording (Gemini-prepared inputs made beforehand are OK; disclose them), and only free-to-use files (CC0 or public domain, with the source link).

You'll have to outline the following:

1. **Domain / Role:** what field this task is from, and who would do it (e.g. music producer).
2. **Goal:** what you're trying to accomplish.
3. **Starting materials:** say if you're starting from scratch, or if you'd bring existing files. Describe the existing files.
4. **Steps:** a rough outline of how you'd do the task, showing your professional expertise. Name the apps you use for each step. You'll need to list all of the apps again in **Apps** below.
5. **Deliverable:** anything you'd plan to upload as part of the task.

An automated agent called an "Idea Check" reads this box, and your recording is later checked against it. **Include every item below.** Missing or inconsistent items are the most common reason ideas get sent back.

Describe your idea

Your description of the professional / expert task you will model goes here, using the template. Pick your apps in the next card.

Describe your idea*

Answer after each of the five headings. See 'What your idea must include' above.

Domain / Role:

Goal:

Starting materials:

Steps (with the apps for each):

Deliverable:

Apps

Apps

Type each app you'll use and press Enter (suggestions appear as you type). Any app is fine unless it's banned (🚫 RESTRICTED).

UDPATE 10/22:

- **Safari and Chrome are now permitted apps.**
- **TextEdit is banned and can only be used for creating metadata.rtf.**
- **NOTE:** We've noticed recording issues when writers use Excel with TaskRecorder. To avoid problems with your recordings, we recommend using an alternative like Google Sheets or Excel in a browser.

Select options...

Your original idea (written before Oct 19)

If you proposed your idea before the form changed, the rest of your original answers are here. Use them with 'Describe your idea' for your opening note and TaskRecorder.

Starting materials

Let us know if you are starting from scratch or using existing materials. Any existing materials can mean you have files, data or a project you might have before you begin recording.

Starting from scratch | Using existing material

What is already available?

For example: A workbook with cleaned sales data, but no charts or calculations.

For example: A workbook with cleaned sales data, but no charts or calculations.

What will you actually create, analyze or decide?

For example: Compare regional sales in a workbook and identify which products need attention.

How will you verify the result?

For example: Reconcile totals to the source data and test each region filter.

Previous work

Is this new work or a continuation?

New task | Continuation of a task

Submit your idea

After you submit, you will press a button that triggers an automatic agent that will check your idea against other submissions and the criteria we listed above.
You will not be able to continue if it doesn't pass this step.
The automatic idea check usually finishes in about a minute.

Stay on this page or come back shortly: the result appears in the Idea check result card below. If the idea is sent back, you will also get a Slack reminder.

Submit idea

Idea check result

While your idea shows Checking Idea, the check is running. It usually takes about a minute, so refresh the page to see the result. If it is still checking after a few hours, it is re-run automatically within a day.

Idea check report

2. Set up your tech

One-time setup: 5 steps you only do once.

One-time setup

Do these once, when you first join Odin. Then answer **Yes, I did this step** for each one in the checklist below. You can't submit your task for review until every step is Yes.

Step	Writer Guidelines	Download
1. Install Xcode	Download & Install Xcode	Xcode (Mac App Store)
2. Turn on Accessibility Inspector	Set up Accessibility Inspector	None
3. Install TaskRecorder 2.4.4	Download & Install TaskRecorder	**Download TaskRecorder** card below · Apple silicon backup: Google Drive
4. Give TaskRecorder its permissions	Set up TaskRecorder · Grant Permissions and Open TaskRecorder	None
5. Set your clock (date + seconds) and Dock (left or right)	Change Required UI Elements	None

📘 Full instructions: Technical Setup in the Writer Guidelines

World files

Download all

Search files...

filesystem 1

TaskRecorder2.4.4.dmg 6 MB

TaskRecorder2.4.4-Intel.dmg 6.4 MB

One-time setup checklist

Answer in order: each question appears once the one before it is Yes.

1. Install Xcode: did you do this step?

Select...

3. Creating your task

Before Recording (Task Plan)

Watch: Before Recording (Task Plan)

Watch: In Depth Before Recording (Task Plan)

Still confused? Watch a more in depth explanation of Before Recording (Task Plan)

Your task plan

Made from your approved idea. The intro doc is what you show on screen at the start.

Prompt/Description

What you will do in this recording. Approved before you record.

Intro doc (show at the start)

Made from your approved idea. Open it on screen at the start of your recording.

No files uploaded

Checklist

This is the most important document in this manual: Please verify that you have completed every item before submitting, this checklist will help you be most successful quickly!

Before Recording (Task Plan)

- **Workpuls/Insightful:** Run Insightful for eligible active hourly work within your applicable allowance or firm weekly cap; pause for breaks. Keep it off for qualifying older tasks retaining prior per-task terms. Tracking first-task milestone work does not make it hourly. See the Payments guidelines for the exact eligibility and October 23 submission deadline.
- **Metadata.rtf:** Before recording, download the Metadata.rtf template from your claimed task in Studio. Complete Topology, Request, and Task Description.
- **Metadata Consistency:** The Request section of Metadata.rtf matches the Goal in TaskRecorder. Topology and Request describe the same objective, inputs, app order, methods, and outputs.
- **Input Files:** If applicable, prepare files free of private or non-public PII, CC0 or public domain sources only.
- **Input Provenance:** In Final Notes, record actual non-AI source URLs or exactly “AI-generated before recording”; complete Source of Data when applicable.

Confirm you're done

Coming soon

Confirm: Before Recording (Task Plan)

- [ ] I did every Before Recording (Task Plan) item above.

Before Recording (Prepare)

Watch: Before Recording (Prepare)

Watch: In Depth Before Recording (Prepare)

Checklist

Before Recording (Prepare)

- **Storage and Power:** The Mac is connected to power and has enough free storage for the complete recording and archives.
- **Clean Workspace:** Hide personal accounts, notifications, recent files, and private information; close project materials before recording.
- **Focus Mode:** Get into Do Not Disturb or “Focus mode” to avoid any notifications.
- **Minimal Background Noise:** Make sure you are recording in a quiet environment.
- **Accessibility Inspector:** Accessibility Inspector is running with its window closed.
- **UI Diversity:** Change at least one per recording; more is better: wallpaper, light or dark mode, accent color, Dock size, sidebar icon size, screen resolution, or an in-app theme.
- **Mouse cursor:** Mouse cursor size & color must stay default.
- **Recording Settings:** The selected display and resolution match Studio; TaskRecorder permissions are green, and the microphone is on.
- **Dock Visibility:** Keep the Dock visible and set it to left or right, not bottom. Automatically hide is off and indicators for open apps are on.
- **Clock Seconds:** Seconds are displayed on the menu bar clock.
- **Open Apps:** Fully launch, log in, load, open required files/workspaces; minimize to the dock.
- **Background Apps:** Quit unused apps, calls, and unnecessary background utilities; keep TaskRecorder and Accessibility Inspector running.
- **Task Description (Goal):** Open the approved Goal document behind the TaskRecorder window.
- **Prefill TR:** Paste the approved Goal and genuine used apps in TaskRecorder.

Confirm you're done

Confirm: Before Recording (Prepare)

- [ ] I did every Before Recording (Prepare) item above.

During Recording (Record and Validate)

Watch: During Recording

The most successful experts on this project, have examined this video first, ensuring that they learn how to get the recording right when they submit. Watch the five minute video below to learn the criteria of an excellent example.

Writer cheat sheet

Consult this one-page guide to set you up for success during your recording! We recommend having it next to your computer screen while you record your task.



Checklist

During Recording (Record and Validate)

- **Minimize TR:** Immediately minimize TaskRecorder after clicking Start Recording.
- **Continuous Recording:** Use one uninterrupted recording from Start Recording through the saved final output and Stop Recording.
- **Brief Intro:** In under 20s, say the intro sentence, minimize or close Task Description (Goal), and begin.
- **Recording Length:** Plan for a recording, including the short intro, that is at least 15 minutes and no more than 50:59 minutes (15:00-50:59).
- **Narration:** Prioritize WHAT you do and WHERE the exact element is on screen so a listener can follow with eyes closed. Explain WHY when useful for reasoning or a non-obvious decision. Why is secondary, with no per-action requirement or equal coverage threshold. Narration speed and task complexity are not acceptance criteria.
- **Audio Quality:** Speech is clear and synchronized with the screen; narration and any task-relevant audio are audible.
- **Audio Gap:** No single silent gap over 45s.
- **No Profanity:** No profanity in narration or shown in recording.
- **No AI Use During Recording:** Show no AI interaction or policy-violating content
- **No PII:** Show no private or non-public PII or project references; follow the documented public GitHub and research-author exceptions.
- **Mouse Activity:** Keep the pointer active. Detected idle stretches are reviewed and called out in delivery; they do not alone require rejection or re-recording.
- **Teaching Pointer:** Point to what you describe, move naturally, and allow about one second around completed clicks so viewers can follow.
- **Limited Typing:** Keep the workflow mouse-driven and avoid long typing blocks
- **Keyboard Shortcuts:** Use visible mouse actions when practical; explain every necessary keyboard shortcut as you use it.
- **Window Management:** Keep one ordinary task window clear or arrange task windows side by side. Review detected overlap as a delivery callout; it does not alone require rejection or re-recording.
- **Metadata.rtf:** The Metadata.rtf file not shown during recording.
- **Workpuls/Insightful:** The Insightful window not shown during recording.
- **Keep TR Hidden:** TaskRecorder remains hidden during recording; only open again before stopping.

Confirm you're done

Confirm: During Recording (Record and Validate)

- [ ] I did every During Recording (Record and Validate) item above.

History